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INDEPENDENT

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YOUR GUIDE TO

Dining and Entertainment

with TEDD THOMEY

Jorge plays with 'gentle brilliance'

Jorge Aguilar, who formerly played professional baseball in Mexico, Arizona and Texas, strums electric guitar and sings nightly at the Captain's Quarters restaurant. He is a native of El Salvador in Central America.

in person

By TEDD THOMEY
Restaurant Editor

THE HAND THAT STRUMS THOSE STRINGS ONCE HURLED A BASEBALL AT BLISTERING SPEED AND IS STILL ADEPT AT GOLF AND PING PONG — I had the pleasure the other evening of hearing once again a unique guitar artist. His name is Jorge Aguilar. I ran across him at the entertainment bar of the Captain's Quarters terrace restaurant, Pacific Coast Highway near Anaheim Street, where he performs Tuesday through Saturday nights starting at 8:30, featuring delightful calypso, Mexican songs sung in Spanish and English and old and new American pop standards.

Jorge has been performing locally for nearly 20 years and has a large following of devoted fans who love his polished performances. Perhaps the best description of his style is contained in the words of Kathleen Brown, a payroll clerk at the Long Beach Naval Shipyard, who was inspired to say: "Jorge's music is filled with gentle brilliance."

Jorge plays his electronic, amplified guitar in the classical Latin style. The nails of his left hand are cut short to press the keyboard firmly. But the nails of his right hand are long, enabling him to strum the strings with a perfect light touch without using a pick. Much of his work is low key and restrained. His voice is a rich, smooth, full baritone. At times, however, his artistry reaches crisp, louder dramatic heights, such as his stirring climax to "Granada" which ends with the cry of "ole!" and the reward of smashing applause.

Handsomely Latin, Jorge has dark eyes filled with humor and dark wavy hair without a hint of gray, although he has lived slightly more than half a century. Many of his fans think he is Mexican. But he isn't. Jorge is a Central American, born in San Salvador, the capital of the tiny republic of El Salvador.

When he was a small boy, Jorge longed to play the piano. But his father, a restaurant owner, told him: "A piano is too costly. So I will buy you a guitar." He spent several dozen colones (2 1/2 colones equal \$1), purchasing a beautiful acoustic guitar which Jorge loved very much. For two years — from about age 10 to 12 — Jorge took classical lessons.

He progressed rapidly because he was willing to practice many hours each week. He also had another interest which he loved equally well — "beisbol." Jorge and his neighborhood pals played baseball as often as they could in a nearby city park. The coordination which made him a promising guitarist also made him a natural baseball player. He was a bit larger and stronger than the other boys his age, able to bat well, make sparkling catches in the outfield and rifle the ball to home plate.

Jorge played baseball at Joaquin Rodezno elementary school and later was a star on the El Salvador High School team. His throws from the outfield had such blistering speed that his high school coach soon converted him into a pitcher. Before he finished high school he was signed to a professional baseball contract, playing for Monterey in the Mexican League. For many years after that, Jorge — who was 5 feet 10 inches tall and weighed 155 — was a star right-hand hurler for teams on both sides of the Mexico-U.S. border. He played three years in the Mexican League. He played for four years for El Paso in the Arizona-Texas League and also played winter ball in the Mexican Coast League.

His best pitch was his fast ball — a fireball that was just a small blur as it streaked across the plate. In 1941 he was honored by being selected to pitch for his country in the Pan-American baseball championships in Cuba. "Our team lost," recalls Jorge, "in fact, I think we came in last — but it was a great honor just to play."

Despite the record of his team, Jorge's performance in the championships was outstanding. He set a record of 14 strikeouts pitching against Nicaragua.

Throughout his years in baseball, Jorge kept his guitar near. He played it in locker rooms and hotel rooms. "But most of all," he said, "I played it on the bus during those long trips from town to town on the baseball circuit. Some of those trips lasted 8 to 10 hours or more. We all sang and many of the guys played their guitars, too. Without our music, we would have been in terrible shape on the road, because the highways were so rough and those buses were old and uncomfortable."

Jorge played in the Mexican League when the competition was extremely tough because many of the United States' top players "jumped" illegally from the National and American leagues, lured by high salaries offered by Mexico's teams. Sometimes Jorge pitched against such star hurlers as Sal Maglie and other Americans of his caliber. Nevertheless, Jorge's record was good. His overall pitching record was better than 300. He was extremely strong, renowned for the number of innings he could pitch in a season. Often he pitched more than 250.

Andy Cohen, former second baseman for the N.Y. Giants, was so impressed with Jorge's ability that he recommended him for promotion to the major leagues in the U.S., playing for the Boston Red Sox. The deal fell through and Jorge continued to play in Mexico, Arizona or Texas. The best game he ever pitched was in 1945 when he hurled a one-hitter while playing for Juarez in Mexico's Central League against Chihuahua. It was the final game of the playoffs and Jorge won the pennant with a 1-0 gem.

His baseball career led him directly to a professional music career. One of his teammates on the El Paso squad was Diamond Cecil, of Long Beach, who played first base. Diamond was impressed with the artistry Jorge revealed while singing and playing his guitar on those long road trips. Diamond is the son of the late Grace Ashley, owner of Ashley's El Encanto Mexican restaurant on Fourth Street. He told his mother about Jorge and she sponsored him, making it possible for him to live and work in America.

Jorge arrived in Long Beach in 1954. He performed at Ashley's for five years. After that he played at many other restaurants in the Long Beach-Orange County area, including the Chart Room in Naples (off and on for nearly eight years), the Corsican Room, the Grotto, Newport Beach, and the Branding Iron, Anaheim. His fans at the Captain's Quarters come from everywhere, such as Mr. and Mrs. Frank Johnson who drive up regularly from their home in San Clemente.

Jorge is still athletically inclined. He plays a strong game of golf, shooting in the low 80s, and is known as a devastating ping pong player. But his chief love is his music and he reveals that love every night as he offers a marvelous repertoire of different moods, ranging from such calypso as "Jamaica Farewell" and "Yellow Bird" to such inspiring Latin songs as "Sabor a Mi," "La Malagueña," "Cucurucue" and "Cuando Calienta El Sol." He also does many Hawaiian hits as well as such newer contemporary sparklers as "Tie a Yellow Ribbon Around the Old Oak Tree" and "Killing Me Softly." His guitar technique is exquisitely light.

Owned for more than three years by Mr. and Mrs. Bill Van Solingen, the Captain's Quarters has seating for 75 in its nautical-style dining room. It is open for luncheon and dinner. No. 1 chef Glenn Nielsen turns out delectable nightly specials, \$3.25 to over \$4.95. The regular entrees include over a dozen of the finest sea food delicacies, including cloppino; gourmet ocean combinations, prime rib barbecue ribs and choice steaks. They are priced from \$3.95 and come with choice of two: sea food cocktail, soup or chowder or salad.

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